SPIRITS

TREND

Clockwise from left: Interrios of Oxymorons, Hyderabad; Random Order at Oxymorons; Guntur Chilli Chicken at Cavity at Barbet & Pals, New Delhi; Mille Feuille of Chilled Salmon and Watermelon Tartar at After Dinner, Goa





Cocktails with character

The drinks too become part of the storytelling experience. The Hidden Club, 'Silk Sheets' reimagines the classic Prohibition drink 'Between the Sheets' through the nostalgic flavours of rum and raisin chocolate, while at Oxymorons; cocktails such as 'Random Order', made with soy, banana, Okinawa sugar and dark rum, and 'Loud Whisper', featuring chicken broth, Wai Wai masala and vodka, prove that guests are increasingly willing to venture beyond familiar flavour profiles.

Goa's After Dinner takes on a more playful route. The 'Pandan Negroni', inspired by the bedroom, has emerged as one of its signature cocktails, while 'Lollipops & Rainbows', inspired by a child's room, remains a favourite for those looking for something lighter and definitely fruitier.

At PCO's Director's Room, guests don't order from a conventional menu. Instead, they respond to scents, postcards inspired by travel and personal cues, allowing bartenders to create bespoke cocktails built around individual memories.

Returning to roots

If storytelling has become the language of India's speakeasy movement, local ingredients have become its vocabulary. Delhi's Cavity has a cocktail menu that celebrates India's geographical diversity through GI-tagged ingredients sourced from across the country. From Sundarbans' honey, Tripura's Queen Pineapple, Ladakhi apricots to Coorg coffee and Bhimkol bananas, the nation is truly celebrated on the menu.

"Every GI-tagged ingredient carries a story of a place, a community and a tradition," says co-founder Jeet Rana. "The idea is to let guests travel across India through flavour, one course at a time."

Down South, Hyderabad's Oxymorons experiments with gongura, amaranth, curry leaves and even chicken broth, using techniques such as fermentation, clarification and fat-washing to transform familiar flavours into something unexpected.

"We always look local before looking elsewhere," says Guha. For him, however, experimentation only succeeds if guests enjoy the drink enough to order it again.

Food joins the conversation

There was a time when food at bars existed largely to accompany drinks. Today, it has become an integral part of the experience. That was evident during my evening at The Cloak Society. While the cocktails naturally drew attention, it was the succulent King Oyster and Napa Cabbage Skewers, the crisp Burrata Taco and the umami-rich Ragi Tostadas that lingered on in my memory long after the final sip. The food wasn't there to fill a gap between drinks; it completed the story.

Elsewhere, Oxymorons' Mutton Sukkha and Ricotta Bhurji have become favourites alongside its inventive cocktails. At After Dinner, guests often pair drinks with the Mille-Feuille of Chilled Salmon and Watermelon Tartar, while PCO's pizzas and unlimited popcorn have quietly developed a loyal following of their own.

Beyond the hidden door

Ironically, in the age of Instagram, few speakeasies remain truly a secret. Hence, it all comes down to how completely the space manages to draw guests into its world.

"Our vision was never simply to create another cocktail bar; but a different world guests could step into," says Colin Tait, Director of Beverage at The Ritz-Carlton, Bangalore. "From the arrival rituals and lighting to the choreography of service, every detail is designed to make guests disconnect from the outside world and immerse themselves in the experience."

And this experience is only going to become all the more immersive with technology, believes Agarwal from The Leela Palace Bengaluru. "The next generation of speakeasy bars will not only offer exceptional drinks but also create memorable, technology-driven journeys: from hidden digital entry systems and immersive projection mapping to AI-powered personalisation and interactive cocktail experiences."